

RP02

Chief Minister and the Council of Ministers of Rajasthan

About 2-3 questions a paper. The firsts among Chief Ministers and the four spells of President's Rule are documented repeats - 2013, 2016, 2023 and 2024 all used them.

The Governor is the head of the State on paper; the Chief Minister runs it in fact. This chapter is half constitutional Articles - 163, 164, 167 - and half a list of names with dates. RPSC takes questions from both halves, and it takes President's Rule from here almost as often as from the Governor chapter.

Chief Minister of Rajasthan

Articles

- 163 aid and advice
- 164 appointment
- 164(1A) 15% cap
- 164(4) six months
- 167 duties to Governor
- 177 right to speak

Records

- Sukhadia longest, about 17 years
- Devpura shortest, a fortnight
- Shekhawat first non-Congress
- Joshi, Shekhawat, Gehlot - three terms each

Council of Ministers

- Cabinet Minister
- Minister of State
- Deputy Minister
- Maximum 30 in Rajasthan
- Minimum 12

President's Rule

- 1967 Sukhadia
- 1977 Hari Dev Joshi
- 1980 Shekhawat
- 1992-93 Shekhawat

Firsts

- Heera Lal Shastri - first
- Tika Ram Paliwal - first elected
- Barkatullah Khan - only Muslim
- Jagannath Pahadia - first SC
- Vasundhara Raje - first woman

Machinery

- CMO
- Cabinet Secretariat
- Chief Secretary as Cabinet secretary
- Deputy Chief Ministers

What the Chief Minister is, constitutionally

Read Article 163 slowly. It says there shall be a Council of Ministers with the Chief Minister at the head to aid and advise the Governor in the exercise of his functions, except in so far as he is required to act in his discretion. That single sentence is the whole parliamentary system in Rajasthan. The Governor is the formal head; the real executive is the Council of Ministers, and its head is the Chief Minister.

Article 163(2) adds the sting - if a question arises whether a matter is one in which the Governor must act in his discretion, his decision is final. Ministers cannot litigate that question, and courts will not inquire into what advice was given. Article 163(3) makes the advice itself non-justiciable.

The Articles of this chapter

Article	Subject
163	Council of Ministers to aid and advise the Governor
164(1)	Chief Minister appointed by the Governor; other Ministers on the CM's advice
164(1A)	Size of the Council - not more than 15% of Assembly strength, not fewer than 12
164(2)	Collective responsibility to the Legislative Assembly
164(3)	Oaths of office and secrecy administered by the Governor
164(4)	A non-member Minister must become a member within six consecutive months
165	Advocate General of the State
166	Conduct of business of the State Government
167	Duties of the Chief Minister towards the Governor
177	Right of Ministers to speak in the House

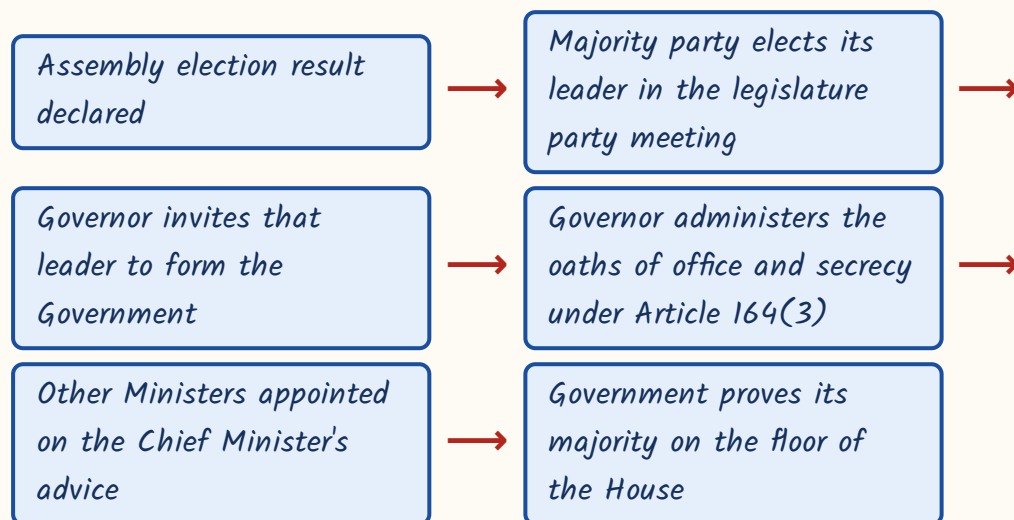
TRAP

Ministers hold office during the pleasure of the GOVERNOR, not of the Legislative Assembly. They are collectively responsible TO the Assembly. Those are two different sentences and RPSC swaps them in NOT-correct questions.

Appointment, oath and tenure

The Constitution says nothing about how the Governor is to choose a Chief Minister. Convention fills the gap - he calls the leader of the party or coalition that commands a majority in the Assembly. Where no one clearly commands a majority, the choice becomes a discretionary act, and that is where Governor-CM disputes begin.

How a Chief Minister takes office in Rajasthan



- There is no minimum qualification beyond being qualified for membership of the Legislature - 25 years of age for the Assembly.
- A person who is not a member of the Legislature can be appointed Chief Minister, but must get elected within six consecutive months - Article 164(4).

- There is no fixed term. The Chief Minister holds office as long as he enjoys the confidence of the Assembly.
 - The salary and allowances of Ministers are determined by the State Legislature.
 - A member disqualified on the ground of defection cannot be appointed a Minister for the duration of that disqualification - added by the 91st Amendment.
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- Heera Lal Shastri, the first Chief Minister, was nominated by the Rajpramukh in April 1949 - there was no elected Assembly then.
 - C.S. Venkatachari, the second, was an administrator brought in from outside the legislature altogether.
 - Tika Ram Paliwal became the first Chief Minister to hold office after an election, in March 1952.

Powers and functions of the Chief Minister

Think of the Chief Minister in four relationships - with the Governor, with the Council of Ministers, with the Assembly, and with the administration. Learn the list in that order and you will never lose a NOT-a-function question.

- With the Governor - he is the sole channel of communication under Article 167.
- He advises the Governor on appointing Ministers, the Advocate General, RPSC members, the State Election Commissioner and the Lokayukta.
- With the Council - he allocates portfolios, can reshuffle them, presides over Cabinet meetings, and his resignation or death dissolves the entire Council.
- With the Assembly - he is the Leader of the House; he advises the Governor on summoning and proroguing the House and on its dissolution; he announces major policies on the floor.

- With the administration - he is chairman of the State Planning Board and of the Rajasthan State Disaster Management Authority, and the political head to whom the Chief Secretary reports.
- Article 167, duty one - communicate to the Governor all decisions of the Council of Ministers on administration and on proposals for legislation.
- Duty two - furnish any information relating to administration or legislation that the Governor calls for.
- Duty three - if the Governor so requires, place before the Council any matter decided by a single Minister but not yet considered by the Council.

TRAP

The Chief Minister does NOT appoint judges of the Rajasthan High Court. Judges are appointed by the President on the recommendation of the collegium, with the Governor consulted. This is a standing NOT-a-function distractor.

The Council of Ministers - size, ranks and the 91st Amendment

Before 2003 a Chief Minister could build a ministry as large as his coalition needed. The 91st Constitutional Amendment Act, 2003 stopped that. It inserted Article 164(1A) - the total number of Ministers, including the Chief Minister, shall not exceed 15 per cent of the total strength of the Legislative Assembly, and shall not be fewer than 12.

Apply it to Rajasthan. The Assembly has 200 members. Fifteen per cent of 200 is 30. So the Rajasthan Council of Ministers can have at most 30 members including the Chief Minister. This arithmetic question is asked directly - the answer is 30.

Ranks in the Council of Ministers

Rank	Position
Cabinet Minister	Heads a department; only Cabinet Ministers attend Cabinet meetings
Minister of State	May hold independent charge or be attached to a Cabinet Minister
Deputy Minister	Attached to a Minister; assists him, does not attend Cabinet

- The minimum of 12 applies to every State, however small the Assembly.
- Only Cabinet Ministers attend Cabinet meetings; the Cabinet is a smaller body than the Council of Ministers.
- The Constitution nowhere uses the word Cabinet for the States except in Article 352 - the ranks are a matter of convention and rules of business.
- The 91st Amendment also inserted Article 361B - a defector is barred from any remunerative political post for the period of disqualification.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre style on the 91st Amendment - the maximum permissible size of the Rajasthan Council of Ministers including the Chief Minister is 30, and the constitutional minimum for any State is 12.

YAAD RAKHO

Yaad rakho the formula - 15 per cent of the House, floor of 12. Rajasthan 200 seats, so 30. If a question gives you another State's Assembly strength, do the same sum.

Responsibility - collective and individual

Article 164(2) says the Council of Ministers shall be collectively responsible to the Legislative Assembly. In practice it means the ministry stands or falls

together. Once a decision is taken in Cabinet, every Minister must defend it outside, whatever he argued inside. A Minister who cannot must resign.

Collective vs individual responsibility

Collective responsibility	Individual responsibility
Article 164(2) - stated in the Constitution	Article 164(1) - flows from holding office during the Governor's pleasure
Owed to the Legislative Assembly	Owed to the Governor, in practice to the Chief Minister
A no-confidence motion carried against one Minister brings the whole Council down	The Governor may remove a single Minister on the Chief Minister's advice
Cabinet decisions bind every Minister in public	A Minister answers for his own department's acts

- Oath of office and secrecy is administered to every Minister by the Governor - Article 164(3).
- If the Assembly passes a no-confidence motion, the whole Council must resign, not merely the Minister named.
- The resignation or death of the Chief Minister automatically dissolves the Council of Ministers; the resignation of any other Minister does not.
- Ministers have the right to speak in and take part in the proceedings of the House under Article 177, but can vote only in a House of which they are a member.

The Chief Ministers of Rajasthan - the complete succession

Read the two tables as one line of names. RPSC asks this in three shapes - a straight one-liner on a first, a match of Chief Minister to period, and a chronological ordering question. The dates matter more than the parties.

Chief Ministers of Rajasthan, 1949 to 1980

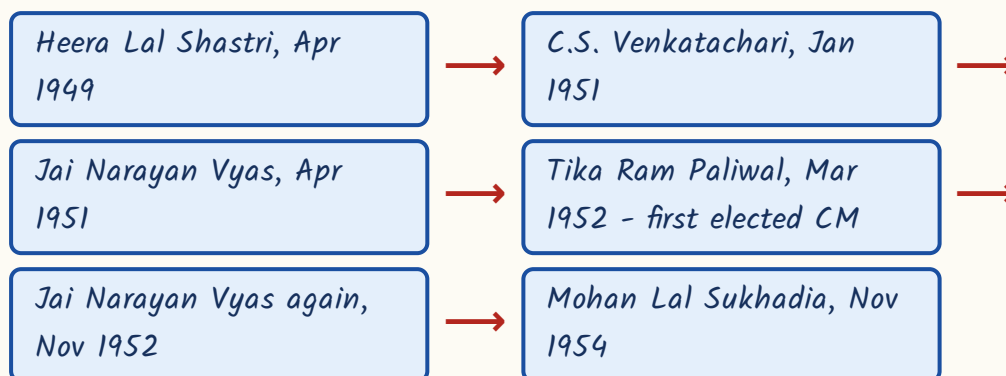
Chief Minister	Tenure	Note
Heera Lal Shastri	7 Apr 1949 - 5 Jan 1951	First Chief Minister; Jaipur Prajamandal leader, nominated by the Rajpramukh
C.S. Venkatachari	6 Jan 1951 - 25 Apr 1951	An administrator from outside the legislature
Jai Narayan Vyas	26 Apr 1951 - 3 Mar 1952	First term
Tika Ram Paliwal	3 Mar 1952 - 31 Oct 1952	First elected Chief Minister; earlier the first Deputy Chief Minister
Jai Narayan Vyas	1 Nov 1952 - 12 Nov 1954	Second term; he had lost from two seats in the 1952 election
Mohan Lal Sukhadia	13 Nov 1954 - 9 Jul 1971	Longest-serving, about seventeen years, with the 1967 break
Barkatullah Khan	9 Jul 1971 - 11 Oct 1973	Only Muslim Chief Minister; died in office
Hari Dev Joshi	1973 - 1977	First of three terms
Bhairon Singh Shekhawat	1977 - 1980	First non-Congress Chief Minister

Chief Ministers of Rajasthan, 1980 to the present

Chief Minister	Tenure	Note
Jagannath Pahadia	1980 - 1981	First Scheduled Caste Chief Minister; his only term
Shiv Charan Mathur	1981 - 1985	First term
Hira Lal Devpura	23 Feb - 10 Mar 1985	Shortest tenure, about a fortnight
Hari Dev Joshi	1985 - 1988	Second term
Shiv Charan Mathur	1988 - 1989	Second term
Hari Dev Joshi	1989 - 1990	Third term
Bhairon Singh Shekhawat	1990 - 1992	Second term

Chief Minister	Tenure	Note
Bhairon Singh Shekhawat	1993 - 1998	Third term
Ashok Gehlot	1998 - 2003	First term
Vasundhara Raje	2003 - 2008	First woman Chief Minister of Rajasthan
Ashok Gehlot	2008 - 2013	Second term
Vasundhara Raje	2013 - 2018	Second term
Ashok Gehlot	2018 - 2023	Third term
Bhajan Lal Sharma	15 Dec 2023 onwards	MLA from Sanganeer; a first-time MLA when chosen

The first six years - the ordering question RPSC likes



- Fourteen individuals have held the office; Hari Dev Joshi, Bhairon Singh Shekhawat and Ashok Gehlot have each held it three times.
- Vasundhara Raje and Shiv Charan Mathur have each held it twice; Jai Narayan Vyas twice.
- Jagannath Pahadia is the standard answer to 'which of these was Chief Minister only once'.
- Hira Lal Devpura went on to become Speaker of the Assembly later in the same month he ceased to be Chief Minister.

The firsts and the records - learn these cold

Every one of these has been asked as a plain one-liner. If you learn nothing else from this chapter, learn this box.

Firsts and records among the Chief Ministers

Distinction	Name	Detail
<i>First Chief Minister</i>	<i>Heera Lal Shastri</i>	<i>From 7 April 1949</i>
<i>First elected Chief Minister</i>	<i>Tika Ram Paliwal</i>	<i>3 March 1952; earlier first Deputy CM</i>
<i>Longest tenure</i>	<i>Mohan Lal Sukhadia</i>	<i>Nov 1954 to Jul 1971, about 17 years</i>
<i>Shortest tenure</i>	<i>Hira Lal Devpura</i>	<i>23 Feb to 10 Mar 1985</i>
<i>Only Muslim Chief Minister</i>	<i>Barkatullah Khan</i>	<i>1971-73; died in office</i>
<i>First Scheduled Caste Chief Minister</i>	<i>Jagannath Pahadia</i>	<i>1980-81</i>
<i>First non-Congress Chief Minister</i>	<i>Bhairon Singh Shekhawat</i>	<i>1977-80; later Vice-President of India</i>
<i>First woman Chief Minister</i>	<i>Vasundhara Raje</i>	<i>From 2003</i>
<i>Current Chief Minister</i>	<i>Bhajan Lal Sharma</i>	<i>From 15 December 2023</i>

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 - who was the first Chief Minister of Rajasthan?

Answer: Heera Lal Shastri. Distractors used are Jai Narayan Vyas and Tika Ram Paliwal, so keep the 1949 date attached to Shastri.

TRAP

First Chief Minister and first ELECTED Chief Minister are different people. Shastri was nominated by the Rajpramukh in 1949; Paliwal took office after the 1952 election. Do not confuse the two, and do not confuse Ram Niwas Mirdha, who was a Speaker, with any Chief Minister.

YAAD RAKHO

Trick for the three-timers - J-S-G: Joshi, Shekhawat, Gehlot. Three terms each. Raje and Mathur, two each.

President's Rule in Rajasthan - the documented repeat

This topic has been asked in 2013, in 2016 and again in 2024. Learn it as a story, not as a table, and the table will follow. Rajasthan has been under President's Rule four times, and the same Chief Minister lost his government twice.

The first spell came in March 1967. The fourth general election left the Assembly hung, Mohan Lal Sukhadia could not immediately show a majority, and the State went under Article 356 from 13 March to 26 April 1967. Sukhadia returned when the numbers were settled. The second spell followed the Janata wave of 1977 - Congress governments across north India were dismissed, and Hari Dev Joshi's government went with them, from 30 April to 21 June 1977.

The third and fourth spells both fell on Bhairon Singh Shekhawat. In February 1980, after Indira Gandhi's return at the Centre, his first government was dismissed - President's Rule ran from 17 February to 5 June 1980. Then in December 1992, after the demolition of the Babri Masjid, BJP governments in several States were dismissed; Shekhawat's second government fell on 15 December 1992 and President's Rule lasted until 3 December 1993 - about 354 days, the longest of the four spells.

The four spells - the match question RPSC actually set in 2024

Year	Dates	Government displaced
1967	13 March - 26 April 1967	Mohan Lal Sukhadia

Year	Dates	Government displaced
1977	30 April - 21 June 1977	Hari Dev Joshi
1980	17 February - 5 June 1980	Bhairon Singh Shekhawat (first time)
1992-93	15 December 1992 - 3 December 1993	Bhairon Singh Shekhawat (second time)

- Number of impositions - four. That is the whole answer to the most-repeated version of this question.
- Chief Minister dismissed most often - Bhairon Singh Shekhawat, twice.
- Longest spell - 1992-93, about 354 days.
- Shortest spell - 1967, about 45 days.
- In each case the proclamation was issued by the President under Article 356 on a report from the Governor.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 as a match-the-following - each spell of President's Rule against the Chief Minister whose government was displaced. 1967 goes to Sukhadia, 1977 to Hari Dev Joshi, 1980 and 1992-93 to Shekhawat.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 - a statement question testing that President's Rule has been imposed four times and that Shekhawat's government was displaced twice. Both statements are correct.

The machinery around the Chief Minister, and where things stand now

The Chief Minister does not work alone. The Chief Minister's Office and the Cabinet Secretariat, both housed in the State Secretariat at Jaipur, service the

Council of Ministers. The Chief Secretary of Rajasthan is secretary to the Cabinet - he circulates the agenda, records the decisions and communicates them to departments.

- Cabinet decisions are communicated to the Governor by the Chief Minister under Article 167, not by the Chief Secretary.
- The Rajasthan Government Rules of Business, framed under Article 166(3), decide which matters must go to the Cabinet and which a Minister may decide alone.
- The Deputy Chief Minister is not a constitutional post - it carries the rank and salary of a Cabinet Minister and no extra powers.
- Sachin Pilot was Deputy Chief Minister of Rajasthan from 2018 to 2020.
- In December 2023 two Deputy Chief Ministers were appointed - Diya Kumari, MLA from Vidhyadhar Nagar, and Prem Chand Bairwa, MLA from Dudu.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: Bhajan Lal Sharma of the BJP has been Chief Minister since 15 December 2023, with Diya Kumari and Prem Chand Bairwa as Deputy Chief Ministers. Rajasthan's next Assembly election is due in 2028, so this line-up should hold to exam day - but verify the ministry's size and any reshuffle from the Rajasthan Government portal in November 2026.

REVISION RECAP

1. Article 163 - Council of Ministers with the CM at the head to aid and advise the Governor, except in his discretion.
2. Article 164(1) - CM appointed by the Governor; other Ministers on the CM's advice; all hold office during the Governor's pleasure.

3. Article 164(1A), inserted by the 91st Amendment 2003 - Council not more than 15% of the House, not fewer than 12.
4. Rajasthan's ceiling is therefore 30 Ministers including the Chief Minister.
5. Article 164(2) collective responsibility to the Assembly; 164(3) oath by the Governor; 164(4) six months to become a member.
6. Article 167 - the CM communicates Cabinet decisions, furnishes information, and refers single-Minister decisions to the Council.
7. Three ranks - Cabinet Minister, Minister of State, Deputy Minister; only Cabinet Ministers sit in Cabinet.
8. Heera Lal Shastri - first CM from 7 April 1949, nominated by the Rajpramukh, a Jaipur Prajamandal leader.
9. C.S. Venkatachari second; Jai Narayan Vyas held office twice; Tika Ram Paliwal was the first elected CM in 1952.
10. Mohan Lal Sukhadia - longest, Nov 1954 to Jul 1971, about seventeen years.
11. Barkatullah Khan - only Muslim CM, 1971-73, died in office; Jagannath Pahadia - first Scheduled Caste CM, 1980-81.
12. Hira Lal Devpura - shortest, 23 Feb to 10 Mar 1985; he then became Speaker.
13. Bhairon Singh Shekhawat - first non-Congress CM, three terms, later Vice-President of India.
14. Vasundhara Raje - first woman CM, terms from 2003 and 2013; Ashok Gehlot three terms.
15. Bhajan Lal Sharma - CM since 15 December 2023, MLA from Sanganer, a first-time MLA when chosen.
16. President's Rule in Rajasthan four times - 1967, 1977, 1980 and 1992-93.
17. Sukhadia lost office in 1967, Hari Dev Joshi in 1977, Shekhawat in 1980 and again in 1992-93.
18. The 1992-93 spell of about 354 days is the longest; 1967 at about 45 days the shortest.
19. The CM does not appoint High Court judges - a favourite NOT-a-function distractor.
20. Deputy CM is a political, not a constitutional, post - Diya Kumari and Prem Chand Bairwa since December 2023.